

The Spice Girls

They called themselves The Spice Girls — a **cardamom pod**, a **cinnamon stick**, and a **clove** — who lived in a jar tucked in the corner of Piya's kitchen **shelf**. Left behind by a careless maid while the rest of the spices were **ground** to powder, these three survived and named themselves: the **elegant** clove chose Love of Clove (with a silent "C"), the refined cinnamon stick preferred Amone, from the Egyptian god Amon, and the cardamom pod, claiming **maternal** status due to the seeds she carried, went with Mom.



Their days passed in quiet **dignity** until one morning when Preeti, Piya's **lively** cousin, came to visit. Piya, a **precise** mathematics professor living a strictly scheduled life, hadn't taken a holiday in over three years. When Preeti suggested a break, Piya admitted this fact down to the day. Preeti, **horrified** at such **monotony**, declared, "You need more spice in your life!"

The spices in the jar **exchanged glances**, puzzled by her words. Preeti then revealed a gift from Kufri — saffron. Spotting the jar with Mom, Love, and Amone, she **emptied** them out into a dark corner and replaced them with the saffron threads, unaware of the loss.



"Let's go **trekking** this weekend," Preeti **insisted**. **Reluctantly**, Piya agreed and began planning. **Meanwhile**, Mom tried introducing herself to the **newcomer**. The saffron responded **haughtily**, "I don't need fancy names. I'm the most expensive spice—what more matters?"

The trip turned **disastrous**. After a bone-jarring bike ride and an **exhausting** climb, Piya slipped into a pool while avoiding a snake and **ended up** bitten by leeches. The next day, she twisted her ankle and **dislocated** her shoulder during a fall. **Bandaged** and **sore**, she returned home, secretly hoping Preeti would settle abroad.

While recovering, Piya decided to drink saffron milk for healing but discovered the threads had turned **mouldy**. "Poor quality saffron," she **muttered**, tossing them out. Cleaning the jar, she spotted the forgotten trio — Mom, Amone, and Love — in the corner.



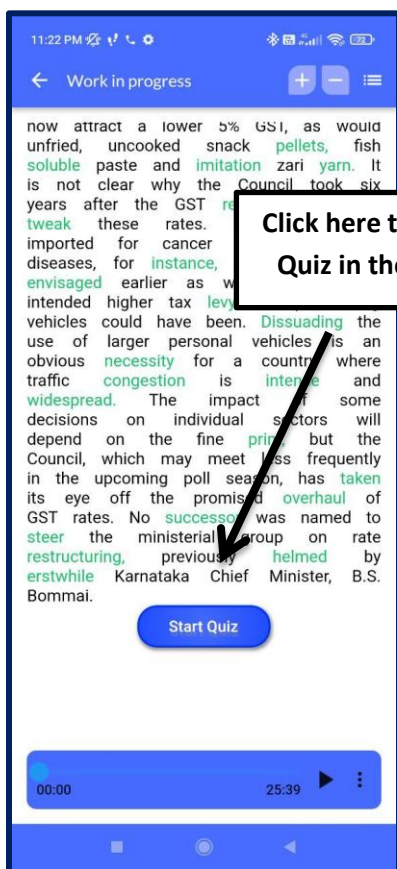
"Oh, here you are!" she **exclaimed**, gently placing them back in the jar. "I should never have allowed you to be replaced. You're all the spice I need in my life."

Vocabulary

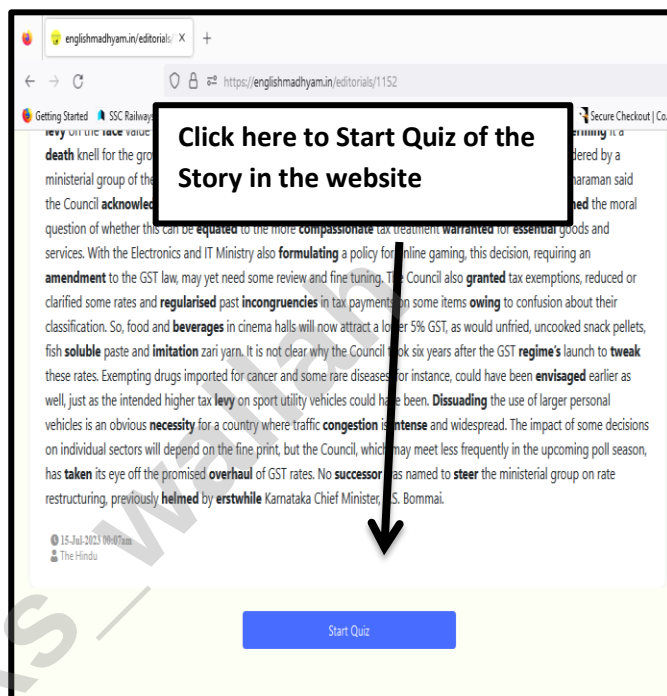
1. **Cardamom pod** (noun) – spice seed, elaichi, aromatic seed, flavoring capsule, condiment इलायची
2. **Cinnamon stick** (noun) – bark spice, dalchini, aromatic wood, flavouring bark, sweet spice दालचीनी
3. **Clove** (noun) – spice bud, laung, aromatic bud, seasoning, pungent spice लौंग
4. **Shelf** (noun) – ledge, rack, bracket, platform, board शेल्फ / ताखा
5. **Grind** (verb) – crush, powder, mill, pulverize, mash पीसना
6. **Elegant** (adjective) – graceful, refined, stylish, sophisticated, polished सुरुचिपूर्ण
7. **Maternal** (adjective) – motherly, caring, nurturing, protective, affectionate मातृत्वपूर्ण
8. **Dignity** (noun) – self-respect, nobility, honor, grace, poise गरिमा
9. **Lively** (adjective) – energetic, cheerful, spirited, active, vibrant जीवंत / उत्साही
10. **Precise** (adjective) – exact, accurate, meticulous, detailed, specific सटीक
11. **Horrify** (verb) – shock, appall, terrify, frighten, stun भयभीत करना
12. **Monotony** (noun) – dullness, boredom, repetitiveness, routine, sameness नीरसता / एकरसता
13. **Exchange** (verb) – swap, trade, share, switch, reciprocate अदल-बदल करना
14. **Glance** (noun) – quick look, peek, glimpse, glimpse, brief view झलक / एक नजर
15. **Empty** (verb) – pour out, unload, evacuate, discard, remove खाली करना
16. **Trekking** (noun) – hiking, walking tour, journey, expedition, mountaineering पैदल यात्रा
17. **Insist** (verb) – demand, urge, persist, emphasize, assert ज़ोर देना
18. **Reluctantly** (adverb) – unwillingly, hesitantly, grudgingly, unenthusiastically, with hesitation अनिच्छा से
19. **Meanwhile** (adverb) – in the meantime, simultaneously, at the same time, concurrently, during this time इस बीच
20. **Newcomer** (noun) – stranger, beginner, entrant, new arrival, novice नया आगंतुक
21. **Haughtily** (adverb) – arrogantly, proudly, snobbishly, disdainfully, conceitedly घमंड से

22. **Disastrous** (adjective) – catastrophic, ruinous, calamitous, terrible, devastating
विनाशकारी
23. **Exhausting** (adjective) – tiring, draining, fatiguing, wearing, strenuous थकाऊ
24. **End up** (phrasal verb) – land up, result in, finish, wind up, finally reach अंत में होना
25. **Bandage** (verb) – wrap, bind, dress (a wound), cover, secure पट्टी करना
26. **Sore** (noun) – ache, wound, inflammation, bruise, pain घाव / पीड़ा
27. **Mouldy** (adjective) – rotten, decayed, stale, fungus-covered, mildewed फफूंदी लगा हुआ
28. **Mutter** (verb) – murmur, grumble, whisper, complain, speak under breath बड़बड़ाना
29. **Exclaim** (verb) – cry out, shout, call out, proclaim, blurt out चिल्लाना / जोर से कहना

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